



MARIE CURIE

Polish–French physicist and chemist
1867–1934

Marie Curie (born Marie Skłodowska) passed all her high school exams a year early. She was frustrated, however, to find that Polish universities did not admit girls. Nothing could stand in the way of her passion for science, so Marie worked as a teacher until she raised enough money to move to Paris, France. There, she could study physics and math at a top university, the Sorbonne.

A French scientist named Henri Becquerel had recently noticed that the element uranium gave out strange, invisible rays. Marie was curious and began her own research. She was astonished to find that pitchblende—a rock containing a little uranium—gave out much stronger rays than uranium itself! This was a clue that it contained another mysterious substance.

Working with her husband, Pierre Curie, Marie set out to investigate.

Be less curious
about people and
more curious
about ideas.

Breakthrough

After years of grinding down pitchblende and working with the powder, Marie and Pierre extracted two new elements. They named them polonium (after Poland) and radium.

The elements gave out so much radiation energy that they glowed in the dark! Marie came up with the word “radioactive” to describe the way they released radiation.

